invaluable insight into why not only Shah-i Mashhad but many contemporaneous mosques and other religious structures, ranging from the Maghrib through Central Asia, were not always precisely oriented toward Mecca.

It is well known that, by the second millennium CE, the mathematical specialties of trigonometry, astronomy, and stellar calculation were sophisticated fields of study throughout the Islamic world.[37] But, pre-modern *qibla* determination had never been a purely "scientific" matter. Architectural *qibla* orientations in particular frequently resulted from "folk astronomy": this was, in brief, a varying combination of the regional or local prevalence of a given *madhhab*; any local awareness of the Ka'aba's own complex cosmography, as well as its orientations according to pre-Islamic wind theory; and topography and/or pre-existing urban development. The preferred *qibla*s of all the *madhhab*s and associated or independent smaller sects are not known – much less the fascinating, socio-historical reasoning behind them.[38] For present purposes, however, it is fortunate that the preferred *qibla*s of the Hanafis and the Shafi'is, the two most prevalent *madhhab*s in Khurasan, *are* known: while the Shafi'is subscribed to a *qibla* due south (180°), the Hanafis subscribed to a *qibla* due west (270°).[39] Nevertheless, in the absence of an exhaustive catalog of architectural orientations across the Islamic world through the thirteenth century, it is still unclear how closely or consistently these prescribed *qibla* orientations were actually followed,[40] even though they were favored by two of the most prominent Sunni *madhhab*s.

The orientation of Shah-i Mashhad along a near exact north–south axis could accommodate either or both of the prevalent Khurasani *madhhab*s' preferred *qibla*s. But the complex's already deteriorated – and worsening – state of preservation (Figures 4.1 and 4.4) impedes more detailed observations. Based on an extant but previously unread *naskh* inscriptional fragment on the monumental southern entrance, A. W. Najimi proposed that the surviving domed chamber at the quadrangular compound's southeastern corner (Figure 4.5) contained the tomb of a deceased male personage, quite possibly the slain Shansabani sultan Saif al-Din (d. AH 558/1163 CE). Although the surviving fragment does not name Saif al-Din specifically, the association is tenable based on the sultan's death having occurred in the general vicinity of the *madrasa*, shortly before its foundation.[41] Furthermore, we recall that Saif al-Din was the brother of Shah-i Mashhad's patron, Queen Jauhar Malik (see above). The poor state of preservation, however, makes it impossible to determine whether there was a *mihrab* in the chamber. And the outright disappearance of the rest of the large compound precludes knowing if one or more prayer areas were housed elsewhere within it, much less their *qibla* orientations. Nevertheless, it is noteworthy that Shah-i Mashhad's overall north–south orientation accommodates the *qibla*s prescribed by both the orthodox *madhhab*s dominant in Khurasan.